

A VISIT TO A SMALL PLANET SCENE I

BY GORE VIDAL

October 3, 1925 – July 31, 2012

In "A Visit to a Small Planet" by Gore Vidal, the scene introduces Kreton, an eccentric alien who arrives on Earth with curious intentions. Through his interactions with humans, the play humorously explores themes of human nature, technology, and war. Kreton's alien perspective creates comedic situations, offering a satirical reflection on the human condition.



SUMMARY

The Play 'A Visit to a Small Planet' is written by Gore Vidal, an American playwright. It is a reflective comedy. It contains the elements of adventure, suspense, and comments about the modern civilization. Kreton, a mystery character from other planet, is the central character. His comments about the earthly civilization are very crucial. Roger Spelding is a very reputed T.V. programmer. He also plays a significant role in projecting the main character. General Powers intervention adds to the feeling of suspense in the play. The setting is purely American. Roger Spelding and General Powers are the symbols of American pride and arrogance. They have fixed notions. They want to see the world through their own perceptions. They do not accept any other force in the Universe. When they encounter a new challenging situation, they are exposed. Both Roger Spelding and General Powers suffer from the disease of self-projection. Like typical Americans, Spelding worships status and money. He does not want her daughter to marry an ordinary farmer. All this sets the background of the play. The real action, however, starts with the appearance of spaceship. There are many speculations about it, which end as the spaceship lands in Spelding's garden and the mystery character emerges from it. His name is Kreton. He starts with an ironical statement that the place where he has landed is much better than he had expected. He also laughs at the idea of nationalities. He just introduces himself as a citizen of the Universe. He criticises the authoritarian attitude of the rulers. He also does not like the idea of censorship in media. He is of the view that the culture on the earth is full of suspicion and doubt. At this point, he ridicules the earthly creatures by saying that civilization is just beginning on earth. Kreton also ridicules men in uniform. He believes that these people are responsible for battles and wars among nations. He also laughs at their intelligence level. Kreton tells General Powers that he is too dull to understand the mathematical notions he would like to share. He also tells his guests that all the modern inventions they feel proud of are very old. Kreton also humbles General Powers by saying that Americans are not worthy enemies. Why should he and his comrades ever think of invading them. The stranger also exposes the limitation of their knowledge. He proves to them that he is much more knowledgeable than the General and his guests. This wealth of knowledge has enabled them to know what the radars can't. General Powers is humbled when he is unable to take control of the spaceship. No one could come closer to it. Kreton finally says them good-bye and leaves for an unknown destination.

Act I, Scene 1

A Visit to a Small Planet opens with a view of television news commentator Roger Spelding's comfortably middle-class home near Manassas, Virginia. General Tom Powers, a friend of Roger's, is explaining to him that an Unidentified Flying Object (UFO) has, for the last twelve hours, been spotted hovering over the Spelding's home. When Roger dismisses the idea, Powers convinces him to look outside—which he does, seeing the craft. Roger, who was planning to announce to a television audience that UFOs do not exist, panics and asks Powers for permission to break the story, the general refuses, stating that this information is "classified."

Ellen, Roger's nineteen-year-old daughter, then appears on the terrace with her boyfriend, whom Roger dismisses as "the boy farmer." She and her boyfriend discuss their plans for the future; these plans are interrupted, however, when the UFO lands outside the house. The hatch opens and Kreton, the visitor from outer space, enters the room. He looks very human, sporting side-whiskers and the garb of an 1860s gentleman. Kreton asks the Speldings to take him to General Robert E. Lee. After some confusion, Kreton explains that he has been studying the inhabitants of Earth as a 'hobby'; he hoped to see the Civil War Battle of Bull Run. He soon realizes, however, that he must have set the wrong coordinates for his time-traveling spacecraft. Invited by Roger (who hopes to interview him on his television show) to come inside, Kreton accepts, thrilled with the prospect of seeing "a real house."

General Powers returns with an aide and in Roger's study begins questioning Kreton. We learn that Kreton is not only from another planet but from another dimension, one where its inhabitants do not die and have the power to read minds—a power that Kreton demonstrates in the general.



EXERCISE 1- POST READING

Q1. What is ironic about Spelding's broadcast at the beginning of the play?

Ans: The play is full of literary devices. The author uses them very craftily. The use of irony is at its peak in the play. In irony the literal meaning of the sentences is totally opposite to implied or intended meaning of the writer or speaker. Roger Spelding concludes his T.V broadcast quoting General Powers that the flying object which has given rise to meaningless suppositions is nothing more than a meteor passing through the earth's orbit. He further quotes General Powers that Americans will be the first to travel in space. The whole assertion is ironic

Q2. How does Kreton prove his extraordinary powers? Write five sentences.

Ans: Kreton and his people do not die. They possess supernatural power. They have the ability to control their thoughts. Kreton can read people's minds. He can tell in advance what will happen next. He can create an invisible wall that keeps him and his spaceship safe from any harm. He flies in a spaceship that has no instrument board.

Q3. What is the purpose of Kreton's visit to the Earth? Or why did Kreton want to visit the earth?

Ans: In the beginning of the play, Kreton says that he has come to the Earth as a tourist. He further asserts that it is his hobby to study the planet, the Earth. He is curious to learn about the civilization on it. Towards the end, he tells the different purpose of his visit. He states that he wanted to witness the American Civil War. He declares at the end of the play that he has come to take charge of the Earth.

Q4. How advanced is the civilization of Kreton as compared to that of the Earth? OR Can the people of the Earth compete with those of Kreton? Or How does Kreton reveal that he does not have any favorable view of earthlings?

Ans: According to Kreton, the civilization on Earth is only at the initial stages. The people of the Earth still stick to their primitive traits. These traits are wonder, fear and pride. The people of the earth are mortal. On the other hand, Kreton, talks about immeasurable progress of the planet he hails from. In Kreton's people are immortal. They can read people's minds. They can foretell any happening too. The people of the Earth cannot compete with those of Kreton. His people are much more advanced scientifically. They can be immortal and can control their thoughts. On the other hand, the Earth's people are mortal. They have not yet gotten rid of their primitive traits. Their civilization is only at the initial stages.

Q5. What is the role of General Powers in the play?

Ans: In the play General powers in a symbol of the superpower, America. He concludes that the visitor is a spy. Kreton has been sent to the Earth by an alien race to study the people. This is an act preparatory to invasion. Later on, it has substantial evidence too. It is through him that we come to know that the visitor has come to take charge of the planet, Earth.

Q6. What does Roger Spelding say about the flying object as he concludes his TV broadcast? OR What statement of General Powers regarding the suppositions about the falling object does Roger Spelding quote as he winds up his TV broadcast?

Ans: Roger Spelding was a renowned media figure. He concludes his T.V broadcast with

the news of spaceship. He quotes General Powers that the flying object has given rise to meaningless suppositions. It is nothing more than a meteor passing through the earth's orbit. He further quotes General Powers that Americans will be the first to travel in space. That's how Roger Spelding concludes his television broadcast.

Q7. What kind of person is Roger Spelding?

Ans: Roger Spelding is an unctuous and ambitious man. He seems to have no opinion of his own. He very obediently, or rather comically, believes what his seniors say. He works as the mouthpiece of others. He boasts of his being closely in touch with General Powers. His exaggeration is the source of humour throughout the play.

Q8. How much does Ellen Spelding like her Father's TV broadcast?

Ans: Ellen Spelding is the daughter of Roger Spelding. She is a lively girl of twenty. She is interested in John Randolph, her fiancé, whom Roger Spelding does not like. She fidgets as she listens to the broadcast of her father. He grumbles at her conduct. According to him, it is her indifference to the limelight he enjoys. Her father had expected very excited and enthusiastic reaction from her side.

Q9. Why doesn't Roger Spelding like his daughter's fiancé, John Randolph? OR Does Ellen like her father's idea of marrying an ambitious or wealthy man? OR what kind of man does Roger Spelding wish his daughter to marry? Or why is Roger Spelding unhappy about the relationship between Ellen and John? Or What kind of person is John Randolph?

Ans: Roger Spelding's daughter is interested in John Randolph. John Randolph was her fiancé. Roger Spelding does not like John Randolph at all. Roger Spelding believes that John is a happy-go-lucky person. He is not a hard-working person. According to Roger Spelding, John Randolph is rather ambitious man who will make his mark in the world. Ellen does not agree with her father's idea of her marrying an ambitious or wealthy man. She likes John and believes that he is hardworking man. She likes him for what he is. Roger Spelding believes that there is nothing wrong with marrying a wealthy man. However, he wishes that his daughter was married to a hard-working ambitious man who will make his mark in the world.

Q10. What do the Speldings say as they see something landing in their house? OR What does the visitor from outer space look like? Or What do Mr. and Mrs. Spelding say as they see Kreton getting out of his spaceship? Describe the arrival of the flying saucer in your own words.

Ans: Mrs. Spelding, Ellen and John believe that it is a spaceship as they see something falling right in their house. Roger Spelding, however, disagrees with them. He keeps reiterating that it is either a meteor or a balloon. When it has landed, it is a spaceship. The visitor is in his forties. He is a mild, pleasant-looking man with side-whiskers, and is dressed in the fashion of 1860. He looks perfectly nice to Mrs. Spelding. She likes his side-whiskers. On the other hand, Roger Spelding thinks that the alien is either a monster or an impostor.

Q11. What does Roger Spelding do, as he sees the flying saucer landing in his house and a man getting out of it?

Ans: Roger Spelding sees a flying object landing in his house. He sees a man getting out of it. He at once calls the Army. He declares that General Powers is coming over. He suggests

that he and others should not leave the house until the Army gets there. It clearly shows that his house was under martial law. No one is supposed to leave the place until allowed by General Powers.

Q12. Where does Kreton, come from? OR Which planet or solar system does Kreton come from? OR Why does Kreton say that he cannot explain to General Powers as to where the former has come from? OR How long, according to Kreton, will it take General Powers to understand where Kreton has come from?

Ans: When asked where he is from, Kreton says that he is not from the Earth. He is also not from Mars. He is from other part of the world which is not planet known to the Earth people. He says that he is from another solar system, or rather from a planet in another dimension. He depicts his abode as the most civilized and most powerful place. Kreton says that it is possible that he could explain it to a mathematician as to where he (Kreton) is from, but not to a layman like General Powers for another five hundred years.

Q13. Who is Aide? What is his role in the play? And How does AIDE, describe Kreton's spaceship?

Ans: The captain reports that the flying object is elliptical, with a fourteen-foot diameter. He adds that it is made of an unknown metal that shines, and inside the spaceship, there isn't anything – no instruments, no food, nothing.

Q14. Why and how does General Powers threaten Kreton when AIDE reports that there is no instrument board in the flying object?

Ans: When General Powers comes to know through AIDE that there is no instrument board in the flying machine, he threatens that Kreton will be in very serious trouble if he does not cooperate and tell what he did with his instrument board.

Q15. Why can't Spelding interview Kreton? What hampers his being the first to break the news on TV about the alien?

Ans: Spelding cannot interview Kreton or break the news about aliens in his TV broadcast because General Powers has put complete censorship on any leaking of the story about the alien. General Powers declares that Spelding's house is under martial law.

Q16. Why can't John call his family to tell them that he is all right?

Ans: As John moves to telephone his family to tell them that he is all right, AIDE forbids him to do so, telling him that Spelding's house is a military reservation until the crisis is over. He forbids John to leave the house without General Power's permission.

Q17. How does the playwright expose the inferiority of the present race to that of the future? OR How does the writer compare the people of the two planets?

Ans: Gore Vidal exposes the limitation of the modern civilization in an effective way. He believes that the modern civilisation is not civilised enough. In fact, the civilisation is just beginning on the earth. Modern man knows too little. His knowledge of science and humanities is superficial. Modern man is carried away by superstitions. He is also addicted to self glorification. This has resulted in arrogance and disrespect for others. Consequently, nations are engaged in never ending wars. The writer is also of the view that modern man has not yet learnt to conquer time and space. Men in future civilisation would be quite different. They might live in other planets. According to the writer they will live forever by conquering time and space. They will be much more knowledgeable. They

will not be the victims of hatred. They will live peacefully. The civilization will be in its full bloom. The inhabitants of all the planets will be united. Thus, the future men would be the members of a universal civilisation.

Q18. Write short note on the following characters:

- 1 Mr Spelding 2 Mrs Spelding 3 Ellen 4 General Powers 5 Kreton

1) Mr Spelding:

Mr Roger Spelding is a TV commenter by profession. He lives with his wife and a young, beautiful daughter, Ellen, who wishes to marry John. But Mr Spelding is not much happy with their relationship as he believes that he is not an ambitious and hardworking person and likes to spend his time on the farm. Mr Spelding depends on his friend, General Powers and has faith on his words, thus when John tells them that the spaceship is going to land, he doesn't believe him and keeps a firm opinion that the object is a meteor and not a spaceship. He is a generous man and offers Kreton to spend a night with them.

2) Mrs Spelding:

Mrs Spelding is the wife of Mr Roger Spelding. She is a loving and caring lady. She is very concerned about her husband and daughter, Ellen. She is a housewife and is fond of gardening. She has a very beautiful Rose Garden in her house. Mrs Spelding shows her fears regarding the visitor and tells all the family members to go into the cellar to seek protection. She gets worried about her Rose Garden too as the spaceship lands there. But as soon as she meets the visitor and finds him to be a nice man, she treats him politely and prepares a room for him to take rest. She is a kind lady and deals with others in a humble way.

3) Ellen:

Ellen is a young, cheerful girl and the only daughter of Mr and Mrs Spelding. She likes John and wants to marry him but her father opposes her relationship and he believes that he is not an ambitious person and suggests that she must marry a rich man but she remains assertive and explains to her father that he already has what is needed for a comfortable life and she has no issue that John is a farmer. She further tells him that she is not after money and doesn't require a rich person. She is a well-mannered girl and completely satisfied with her life.

4) General powers:

The role of General Power in the play is very important. He is responsible for the security of USA. He is a very dutiful and strict fellow. He is very active and alert. He questions Kreton and tries to know his reality. He threatens to arrest him if he does not co-operate. He puts the house of Mr. Spelding under martial law.

5) Kreton:

He is very polite and kind to everybody. He behaves very nicely and elegantly. Even when General Power behaves harshly with him, he does not mind and misbehave in response. He does not try to scare others. He does not punish those who try to damage his space ship. He is quite frank and soft with them all. Kreton belongs to some highly advanced world. He has certain extraordinary powers. For example, he can travel in a spaceship without instruments. He is a mind reader. He can speak all languages of the world. He does not die. He can defend himself against any attack.